

Basics of Zen Studies

1. What Do We Do?

Zen studies asks large questions that are simultaneously historical, philosophical, textual, and institutional - questions for which no single kind of evidence is enough. Examples:

- 1 What can a patriarchal lineage establish about historical transmission?
- 2 What did 'sudden awakening' exclude, and did every Chan community mean the same thing by it?
- 3 Can 'ordinary mind' or 'no-thought' be specified without turning them into slogans?
- 4 What is a koan when cases, commentaries, interviews, and curricula are all part of the practice?
- 5 How can Dogen call practice and realization nondual while still prescribing exact training?
- 6 What changes when funerals, ordination, gender, nationalism, and modern institutions are treated as Zen rather than as material surrounding Zen?

2. How Do We Do It?

Through argument disciplined by source criticism. Here is the process you will use in this course. Discover - notice an intellectual reaction to a text, practice, or historical claim. Explore - write down what would have to be true for that reaction to be warranted. Formalize - turn the reaction into an explicit argument and see whether you still endorse it. Locate - identify date, genre, audience, provenance, and translation. Compare - ask whether a rival explanation fits the same evidence. Convey - state the argument so someone who rejects it can recognize it. Receive Feedback - understand the strongest reaction before defending yourself. Start over: Discover - revise the claim rather than protecting the first version.

Open Zen Course

<https://ocw.mit.edu/courses/24-00-problems-of-philosophy-fall-2019/>

ZEN.00 Zen: Texts, Practices, Institutions

Open edition

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